

KING OF THE HILLS (left) A nomad family camping; morning light touches the north face of Kailash

Moudgill's photos show **how he's unsentimental**, both as a photographer and researcher



or his pictures the protagonist of his exhibition, but *Kailash-Mansarovar: A Photographic Journey* bypasses that vanity by focusing on the journeys of two explorers—Sven Hedin and Swami Pranavananda. While the Swedish Hedin came to Tibet "wanting to fill gaps in the world map", Pranavananda, an ascetic traveller, came to the region in 1928, two decades after Hedin, and tried to set right what he felt the Swede got wrong. "Having two protagonists was a challenge. How do you balance them both?"

One only needs to glance through the catalogue of Moudgill's show to know he is unsentimental, both as a photographer and researcher. While he is respectful of Hedin and Pranavananda—they did, after all, "discover" the geography of the Kailash-Mansarovar region—he never hesitates in pointing out how perilous their ambition, and, in some cases, their haste might have been. Hedin and Pranavananda, for instance, disagreed about where the Brahmaputra originated. Not only does Moudgill give us context, he also brings clarity, the way a journalist might.

Many Hindus believe that Kailash is where Shiva dwells, that Mansarovar is where Ganga was tamed, but in Moudgill's images, the mountain and lake are natural wonders first, places of worship later. We see nomads here, not pilgrims. Shot 15-20 years ago, Moudgill says his pictures are already archival. "Since 2007, Tibet has changed multiple times. I last visited Kailash in 2018, and you had everything from mobile telephony and paved roads to four-star hotels and air-conditioned buses."

Moudgill says that Hindus often go to Kailash-Mansarovar with one agenda: "They believe their god lives in Tibet. So, they go there to meet their *bhagwan*, not for any cultural immersion." Several tourism packages now promise a ringside view of Kailash-Mansarovar, but if you end up catching Moudgill's show as it starts to travel, you are sure to feel you're briefly in that ring yourself. ■

Shreevatsa Nevatia



AJEET AND DEEYA BAJAJ have so far completed around a dozen expeditions around the world

tion even as temperatures plunged to -45°C. Ajeet, 57, rates it as the second toughest of the Seven Summits after Mount Everest, which they had climbed from the more challenging north side in Tibet, in 2018.

The Bajaj family has always loved the outdoors. "My father used to take me trekking when I was very young," recalls Ajeet. So, when it was his turn, he started hiking with Deeya and his younger daughter, Meghna—as toddlers, they could often be seen hanging from his back. "Now they ski, do whitewater kayaking, hold black belts in taekwondo and are rescue divers," he says. Deeya, it turned out, had a taste for even more daring adventures. When she was 14, they set off on their first 'major' expedition. "We were a part of an Indo-US team and did a sea kayaking expedition for about 18 days along the fjords of West Greenland," says Ajeet, who is the first Indian to finish the Polar Trilogy. He received a Padma Shri in 2012. "We were out in this mind-blowing wilderness where we would catch fish for dinner, see blue whales and arctic foxes."

Three years later, they embarked on their first extreme expedition—a cross-country skiing expedition across the Greenland ice cap—and have, so far, completed around a dozen expeditions around the world.

Father and daughter share a unique dynamic. "We think alike, especially in emergencies. We just look at each other and know exactly what we are going to do," says Deeya. As honorary ambassadors of the Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao campaign, they aim to spread awareness about the girl child through their expeditions. "In a country like ours, often, I think, women aren't given the same opportunities as men," says Deeya. In a similar vein, Ajeet adds, "Given opportunities, girls can attain the greatest heights possible and that, I feel, will take our country to the next level." ■

Anu Prabhakar